Local Contexts, Global Conversations: Digital History in Central Asia

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Over the past decade, digital methodologies have gradually carved out a space within the humanities disciplines of Central Asia – particularly in Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, and Uzbekistan. While digital humanities as a formally recognized field has relatively shallow institutional roots here compared to Western contexts, the rapid embrace of digital tools for historical research, cultural heritage preservation, and linguistic analysis signals a growing interest in and engagement with digital approaches. This presentation provides initial findings from a large-scale research project on digital history in Central Asia, conducted by the Chair of Modern and Eastern European History at Friedrich Alexander University Erlangen-Nuremberg and its partners in Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, and Uzbekistan. Employing a mixed-methods approach, the study integrates literature reviews, surveys, interviews, site visits, and case studies to thoroughly examine digital history initiatives in the region. By focusing on community engagement and diverse methodologies, the research aims to understand the current state, tools, and challenges of digital history projects in Central Asia.

Regional Context and the Scope of Study. Institutions and researchers in Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, and Uzbekistan have embarked on projects that blend historical scholarship with digital methodologies, including digitizing archives [Archive…; McFadden, Alpysbaeva, Alimgazinov, 2019], building databases, employing computational linguistics for Turkic languages [Abdurakhmonova, Ismailov, Sayfulleyeva, 2022] and preservation of cultural heritage [Ergasheva, 2022; Mukhamadeyeva et al., 2023]. While Tajikistan and Turkmenistan remain less visible in this sphere, these three countries are represented by publicly available projects and scholarly collaborations, serving as a useful lens to understand digital history's trajectory in the region.

From Historical Informatics to Digital History. The terminology and conceptual frameworks used in Central Asia largely trace back to Russian academic traditions. The term "historical informatics" prevails in many instances, reflecting the longstanding influence of CIS "History and Computer" association. This heritage has led many Central Asian historians to adopt computational tools – often statistical and quantitative methods – for historical analysis since the late Soviet period. More recently, however, there has been a gradual shift to broader digital humanities concepts, encouraging scholars to engage with methods from Europe, North America, and beyond. Still, the region's digital history discourse tends to operate in a narrower, more specialized sphere, frequently shaped by Russian-language scholarship and platforms.

Challenges and Opportunities. Despite notable progress, several interrelated obstacles persist. First, underrepresentation in international DH forums is a recurring issue. Researchers from Central Asia seldom appear at global DH conferences.

Second, the region lacks a robust research infrastructure dedicated to digital humanities. Unlike Europe's CLARIN-ERIC and DARIAH-EU, which provide standards, tools, and a supportive network, Central Asia has yet to establish equivalent structures. The absence or at least insufficient quantity of formalized DH centers, specialized journals in local languages, or a small number of degree programs constrains systematic growth. At the same time, this vacuum offers an opportunity: Central Asian scholars can design regionally tailored frameworks that consider local cultural contexts, postcolonial perspectives, and unique historical sources.

Postcolonial Perspectives and Decolonizing Narratives. One of the distinctive scholarly orientations gaining traction in Central Asian digital history is the application of postcolonial digital humanities frameworks [Risam, 2018; Gagarina, Florin, 2024]. This approach questions Soviet and imperial narratives that have long shaped historical discourse, using digital tools to foreground hidden voices and reinterpret archival materials. By leveraging digital techniques – such as text analysis, data visualization, and geospatial mapping – scholars can uncover overlooked patterns, produce more inclusive historical narratives, and challenge lingering colonial biases in existing historiography.

Projects and Thematic Focus. In practice, digital history in Central Asia often centers on two key areas: cultural heritage preservation and the study of Soviet-era repressions. On the heritage side, GLAM institutions and universities have digitized historical artifacts, documents, and museum exhibits, making them accessible to wider audiences. Some projects employ 3D scanning and photogrammetry to virtually reconstruct historical sites

and cultural monuments, broadening the ways researchers and the public can engage with the past.

The second thematic cluster revolves around Soviet repression. Scholars in Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, and Uzbekistan have developed databases and quantitative tools to examine victim lists, administrative records, and biographical data [Ishankhodzhayeva, 2011; Zhanbossinova, 2013; Zhanguttin, 2024]. While this research has yielded promising insights, major challenges remain. Many of these databases are not accessible to external scholars due to privacy concerns, technical limitations, and institutional policies. As a result, collaborative research efforts are hindered, curbing the potential impact of these initiatives.

Community Building and Networking. Recent events have shown that community-building efforts are underway. The 2023 online roundtable "Digital Humanities in Central Asia", for example, attracted more than 150 participants from across the region and beyond. A survey conducted during the round table aimed to assess community needs and gather suggestions for new event formats. The targeted respondents – primarily historians – provided valuable insights into event preferences, including strong interest in educational webinars, online lectures, and online conferences over traditional offline formats. The survey results also confirmed general enthusiasm for digital humanities as a whole, data science applications, and digital history methods [Gagarina, 2024].

Looking Ahead. The current moment represents both a turning point and an opportunity. On one hand, digital humanities in Central Asia struggles with underrepresentation, infrastructural gaps, and the weight of colonial legacies. On the other hand, initiatives are underway to address these challenges. Scholars show growing enthusiasm for digital methods, the community is networking through roundtables and seminars, and postcolonial and global frameworks are reshaping how historical data is interpreted.

As local and international stakeholders collaborate, regionally adapted infrastructures – online repositories, training workshops, data standards, and multilingual platforms – could emerge. The potential to integrate digital humanities into existing academic structures, develop educational curricula, and establish professional associations is clear. In doing so, Central Asian digital history can become more visible, inclusive, and methodologically robust, ultimately contributing not only to regional scholarship but also to the global digital humanities community.

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